12 STEPS · FREE STARTER GUIDE

LinkedIn Optimisation Guide

A practical guide to building a LinkedIn profile that gets you seen, taken seriously, and considered for opportunities.

So, You've Created Your LinkedIn Profile. Now What?

Having a LinkedIn account is one thing. Having a profile that clearly communicates who you are, what you do, and why someone should consider working with you is another.

Your LinkedIn profile is more than an online CV. It is part of your professional presence.

Whether you're looking for your first remote job, trying to land freelance clients, transitioning careers, or simply positioning yourself for better opportunities — your profile needs to tell a clear story.

That's what this guide is about.

> **HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE**
>
> We've broken LinkedIn profile optimization into 12 practical steps so you can work through your profile without feeling like you have to fix everything at once. You don't need to complete all 12 steps in one sitting. Take your time. Make intentional changes. And most importantly, make sure your profile sounds like you.

Let's get started.

01 Start With Your Profile Photo

Before someone reads your headline or About section, they see your photo. That first visual impression matters.

Your LinkedIn photo doesn't have to be expensive or taken in a professional studio. A good phone camera, natural lighting, and a clean background can be enough.

YOUR PHOTO SHOULD

- Clearly show your face
- Be clear and good quality
- Have good lighting
- Have a simple background
- Look professional but still look like you
- Fit the kind of work you're trying to attract

AVOID

- Group photos
- Very dark or blurry photos
- Heavy filters
- Photos where your face is hard to see
- Extremely casual photos
- Cropped photos with another person visible

QUICK CHECK

> *"If someone saw only my photo, would I look approachable and professional?"*

If not, update it.

02 Write a Headline That Actually Says Something

Your headline is one of the most important parts of your LinkedIn profile. Unfortunately, many people waste it.

“Virtual Assistant.” “Looking for opportunities.” “Student.” These don’t tell people enough.

Your headline should help someone quickly understand: **what you do + what you specialize in + who you help or the value you bring.**

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> Instead of: **Virtual Assistant**
> Try: **Executive Assistant | Calendar, Email & Administrative Support | Helping Founders Stay Organised**

> **ANOTHER OPTION**
>
> **Social Media Assistant | Content Scheduling & Community Management | Helping Small Businesses Stay Consistent Online**

YOUR HEADLINE CHECKLIST

- Does it clearly say what I do?
- Does it include my target role?
- Does it contain relevant keywords?
- Does it communicate my specialty?
- Does it tell people something useful?
- Does it match the type of work I want?

> **REMEMBER**
>
> Your headline isn’t supposed to tell your entire life story. It needs to make someone want to click and learn more.

03 Turn Your About Section Into Your Professional Story

Your About section is where your profile starts sounding like a person. Don't treat it like a collection of impressive words.

And please don't start with: *"I am a hardworking, dedicated and passionate individual..."* You can do better.

Your About section should help someone understand who you are professionally, what you do, what you can help with, what experience or strengths you bring, and what type of opportunities you're looking for.

A SIMPLE STRUCTURE

- **Start with who you are.** What do you do professionally?
- **Explain what you can do.** What services, skills, or areas do you specialise in?
- **Show your value.** What problems can you help solve?
- **Add relevant experience or strengths.** What makes you credible?
- **End with direction.** What opportunities, clients, or roles are you interested in?

> **KEEP IT HUMAN**
>
> Write the way you would speak to a professional person. Use short paragraphs. Make it easy to scan. Your About section should sound like you, not like a template.

04 Make Your Experience Section Prove Your Value

Your Experience section shouldn't just be a list of duties. Anyone can say "Managed emails and calendars." The better question is: what did you actually do, and what difference did it make?

FOR EACH ROLE, ASK

- What did I actually do?
- What skills did I use?
- What problems did I solve?
- What responsibilities did I handle?
- What results did I achieve?
- Can I use numbers to demonstrate my work?

WEAK

Managed social media.

STRONGER

Created and scheduled social media content to maintain consistent brand visibility and audience engagement.

And when you have numbers, use them. For example: *Managed scheduling for 3 executives and coordinated 20+ meetings weekly.*

NEW TO REMOTE WORK?

You don't need a long remote-work history to have relevant experience. You can include previous employment, freelance work, internships, volunteer work, relevant projects, or community experience.

Be honest about what the experience was. The goal isn't to make your profile look bigger — it's to make your experience more meaningful.

05 Use Your Banner to Reinforce Your Positioning

Your LinkedIn banner is valuable space. Don't treat it as decoration. Use it to reinforce what you want people to remember about you.

YOUR BANNER CAN INCLUDE

- Your role
- Your specialty
- Your value proposition
- Your website or portfolio
- A simple professional statement

EXAMPLE

EXECUTIVE ASSISTANT
Helping Founders Stay Organised, Productive & Focused

KEEP IT CLEAN — AVOID

- Too much text
- Tiny fonts
- Too many colours
- Cluttered designs
- Random quotes that don't support your brand

And always check how your banner looks on mobile. Your beautifully designed text should not disappear behind your profile photo.

06 Clean Up Your Skills Section

LinkedIn gives you plenty of room for skills. That doesn't mean you need to list everything you've ever done. Your skills should support the professional direction you're trying to build.

ASK YOURSELF

- Does this skill match the work I want?
- Are my most important skills included?
- Do my skills match my headline?
- Do they match my Experience section?
- Have I included relevant tools and platforms?
- Are there irrelevant skills I should remove?

> **THINK IN TERMS OF POSITIONING**
>
> If you're targeting Executive Assistant roles, relevant skills might include: Calendar Management, Email Management, Administrative Support, Executive Support, Project Coordination, Google Workspace, Communication.
>
> The exact skills will depend on your target role. The important thing is consistency — your profile should tell one clear professional story.

07 Show Your Work With the Featured Section

This is where you stop saying “I can do this” and start saying “Here, let me show you.” Your Featured section can act as your proof-of-work area.

YOU CAN FEATURE

- Your portfolio or website
- Work samples or case studies
- Strong LinkedIn posts
- Relevant presentations or projects
- Certifications
- Other work that demonstrates your abilities

> *“If a potential client or employer saw this, would it help them trust that I can do the work?” If yes, feature it.*

DON’T HAVE A PORTFOLIO?

Don’t panic. Start with one strong piece of work. You don’t need ten items — one useful, relevant example is better than a collection of random things.

08 Make Your Education & Certifications Work for You

Your Education and Certifications sections help provide context for your professional journey. But more certificates don't automatically mean a stronger profile. This isn't a certificate collection competition.

REVIEW

- Education
- Certifications and courses
- Professional training
- Relevant credentials

CHECK THAT

- Names are correct
- Institutions are correct
- Dates are accurate
- Relevant qualifications are included

> *"Does this qualification support the type of work I want?" If yes, keep it visible.*

If you recently completed a relevant course or certification, make sure you've added it. Your qualifications should support your story, not distract from it.

09 Add the Sections That Strengthen Your Story

Not every LinkedIn profile needs every possible section. The goal isn't to make your profile look busy — the goal is to make it look intentional.

DEPENDING ON YOUR BACKGROUND, CONSIDER ADDING

- Projects
- Volunteer experience
- Languages
- Organisations
- Awards
- Publications
- Additional relevant experience

> *"Does this information strengthen my professional story?" If yes, add it. If not, leave it out.*

REMEMBER

More information doesn't always mean a better profile. Relevant information does.

10 Clean Up the Technical Details

Sometimes the problem isn't your experience or your skills. It's the small details. Take a few minutes to review your profile settings and contact information.

CHECK

- Your LinkedIn URL
- Location and industry
- Professional email
- Website or portfolio link
- Contact information
- Profile visibility and public profile settings

> *"If someone wants to hire me today, can they easily find me and contact me?"*

Your profile should make it easy for the right person to take the next step.

11 Tell LinkedIn What Opportunities You Want

If you're looking for work, don't leave LinkedIn guessing. Review your Open to Work and job preferences.

CHECK

- Target job titles
- Remote or on-site preference
- Employment type
- Location preferences
- Availability
- Other relevant job preferences

> **BE STRATEGIC**
>
> Don't select 15 completely unrelated job titles because you're hoping something will appear. If you want Executive Assistant roles, make that clear. If you're targeting Customer Support roles, say so. Your profile should communicate direction.

WHAT ABOUT THE GREEN #OPENTOWORK BANNER?

You don't necessarily need to make your job search publicly visible to everyone. If you prefer more discretion, LinkedIn provides an option to indicate that you're open to work to recruiters only, rather than displaying the public banner.

This can be useful if you want to signal that you're job hunting without making it a prominent part of your public profile. Keep in mind that recruiter-only visibility is not an absolute privacy guarantee.

12 Build Social Proof and Do the Final Check

You've made it through the profile. Now let's make it stronger.

ASK FOR RECOMMENDATIONS

Think about people who have actually worked with you — former managers, supervisors, clients, colleagues, internship supervisors, or professional collaborators.

Ask someone who can genuinely speak about your work. Instead of simply saying "Please recommend me," give them context about the work you did together and what you'd appreciate them highlighting.

Authentic recommendations can add credibility to your profile.

THE FINAL 5-SECOND TEST

Find someone who doesn't know much about your professional work. Show them your LinkedIn profile. Don't explain anything. Ask:

> *"Based on my profile, what do you think I do?"*

If they immediately understand who you are, what you do, what you're good at, and what kind of opportunities you're looking for — your profile is doing its job.

If they're confused, don't take it personally. That's useful feedback. Go back and adjust the areas that aren't clear.

Your LinkedIn Profile Checklist

Before you finish, check each box.

- [ ] Profile photo is clear and professional
- [ ] Headline clearly communicates what I do
- [ ] About section explains who I am and the value I bring
- [ ] Experience demonstrates what I can actually do
- [ ] Banner supports my professional positioning
- [ ] Skills are relevant to my target role
- [ ] Featured section shows proof of my work
- [ ] Education and certifications are accurate and relevant
- [ ] Relevant additional sections have been completed
- [ ] Contact information is easy to find
- [ ] LinkedIn URL is clean and professional
- [ ] Open to Work and job preferences are intentional
- [ ] I have considered asking for recommendations
- [ ] My profile passes the 5-second test

THE BIGGER PICTURE

It's Not About Perfect. It's About Clear.

Optimising your LinkedIn profile isn't about making it look perfect. It's about making it clear — clear about who you are, clear about what you do, clear about the value you bring, and clear about what you want next.

And once your profile is clear, don't let it sit there collecting dust. Use it. Post. Connect. Comment. Share your work. Build relationships. Apply for opportunities. Reach out to people.

Your LinkedIn profile is the foundation. Visibility is what you build on top of it.

You don't need to have everything figured out before you put yourself out there. You don't need 10 years of experience. You don't need hundreds of connections. And you certainly don't need a perfect profile.

You need a profile that honestly communicates where you are, what you can do, and where you're going.

Start there. Keep learning. Keep showing up. Keep improving.